Earning Power × Exit Power = Optionality

First make your time valuable. Then make it yours.

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Acknowledgments

PROLOGUE

Eight months

I grew up in the 1990s in a government house.

If you grew up in one, or know someone who did, you know what those two words mean. The house was not ours. It came with my father's job. So did the hospital card, and so did a promise. As long as he kept the job, we would be fine. The house also came with a nameplate, a number painted on the gate by someone with strong views about font size, and a neighbor on each side who knew our business a little better than we did. My mother started working when I was five. In our colony that was early enough to be a topic of discussion. Between the two of them, my parents kept us above water.

We were not poor. I want to be accurate about that, because I have seen poverty up close, and it was not ours.

But there was always a lingering sense of worry in the house that we were one big problem away from real trouble. The problem could arrive in different costumes. An illness in the wrong year. A wedding in a faraway city that we could not skip. A school fee nobody had planned for.

Money came up at our dinner table the way weather comes up in other people's homes. The difference is that weather does not make your parents argue after you have gone to bed. Money did. I would lie awake and try to work out, from how loud the voices were, how bad it was this time. I got quite good

at it. If there were an entrance exam for estimating household cash flow through a closed door, I would have cleared it with a top-ten rank.

I carried that habit into adult life without ever realizing that I was carrying it.

Many years later, at 33, I had a very good year, probably one of the best of my career until then.

My income went up by about 40 percent. I got the title, General Manager, I had been circling for years, the way you circle a parking spot outside a busy mall. Someone senior praised me in a meeting I was not in. I heard about it from a colleague, and I thought about it for a week. When the offer letter arrived, my wife and I went out for dinner. It was a good evening.

About four months later, I was in a meeting where the room was about to make a decision I thought was wrong. Not disastrously wrong. Wrong in a way I could see and others could not, because I was much closer to the detail.

It was a Tuesday afternoon, in a conference room whose name I have forgotten, with a video screen that never worked on the first try until someone from IT walked in and pressed the one button that we had all ignored. The proposal was to pull budget from a program whose numbers I tracked every week and give it to a project a senior leader was attached to. The numbers being quoted in the room were a quarter old. I knew that because I had the current ones open on my laptop, and they pointed the other way. I remember shifting forward in my chair. My mouth was slightly open, which is how most of my brave sentences start.

Then a calculation started in my head unprompted. Somewhere behind my face, a quick estimate ran of what speaking up would cost me. Whose position would I be contradicting? How long would it take to recover if it went badly? What could that person do to my next twelve months?

The result came back fast. Not worth it.

I closed my mouth and sat back. The decision went the way it was always going to go. I said something agreeable about implementation. The meeting ended, and everyone thanked everyone, as is the custom. (Before you judge me, read on.)

That evening, for reasons I could not have explained then, I opened a spreadsheet and did a different calculation. I added up what I actually had. Not what I earned. What, I had, sitting somewhere I could reach easily. Then I added up what my household cost every month. The EMIs. The rent. The nanny. Groceries and help. The insurance. The car loan, which was bigger than it needed to be. The society charges for facilities I hardly used. The yearly things, divided by twelve. And two subscriptions I had forgotten about, one of which was for an app that helped you save money.

Then I divided the first number by the second. The answer was eight. Months, not years.

Eight months. That was how long my family could have gone with no income before our life would have had to become a different life. I had just had a 40 percent year and a new title. By every measure anyone had ever taught me so far, I was doing very well for my age. I was also, it turned out, eight months from a different life.

The part that took me longer to understand was worse than the eight.

I went back through the last three years. My income had nearly doubled. Our daughter had been born the year before, and I had started putting money aside for her. Even so, my runway, counted in months, had grown by only a few. Every raise had gone somewhere, and none of it on anything silly. A bigger flat, because we needed the room. A full-time nanny, because we needed the help. A longer car loan, because the car was nice and the interest rate was low. I could defend every one of those choices then, and I would probably make most of

them again. Together, they meant three years without buying a single extra month of freedom.

A year like that looks exactly like a great year, which is why it is so hard to catch while it is happening. The flat is bigger. There is help at home. The car is newer. The relatives and friends at the next wedding nod at you with new respect. My income had climbed steeply, my runway had barely moved, and nobody around me, including me, had any reason to notice.

A few weeks after the spreadsheet, the last piece fell into place, and it is the reason this book opens in a government house. I had rebuilt my parents' situation, at ten times their income.

They were solvent and one problem away from trouble. So was I. They organized their lives around not losing the job. So did I, in a meeting, on a Tuesday, without ever deciding to. The furniture was better. The math was the same.

There was one difference, and it took me years to see how much it mattered.

My father's job paid little and could not be taken from him. The house, the pension, and the hospital. The whole package was built to last. Everyone in that colony behaved like people whose ground would not move, and it usually did not.

My job paid very well and stood on ground that moves. One restructure, one new boss, or one change in what the market would pay for my skills, and everything my family stood on could be threatened within a quarter. He had security without much money. I had money without much security. I did not know those were two different things, or that the second could produce the same silence in a meeting as the first. This book is about that silence.

Since then, I have done a version of that calculation with dozens of senior people in my network. Almost all of them came out lower than they expected.

One, 36, who works at an IT company and has a newborn at home, said, "I had no clue I was so far from building anything close to a retirement fund." Another, 45, married with two children and working at a consulting firm, said, "This explains my constant anxiety. I had never been able to tell where it came from, but the number explains it."

What I learned from those discussions was that almost no one had done this calculation before, at least not on purpose. They are not careless people. Many of them work with numbers all day, some on very large screens. Like me, they had never been told that this number mattered. The people who advise them on careers do not talk about money, and the people who advise them on money do not talk about careers. This book sits in the gap between those two conversations.

First, a few things this book is not.

It is not a book about escaping work. I like work. I will not spend two hundred pages arguing that the office is a prison and the beach is the answer. Partly because I do not believe it. Partly because you would have noticed by now if it were true and partly because I get sunburns easily. Also, I tried living near the coast for a while. Indian coasts are hot and very humid. I did not last.

It is not a book about retiring early. That is one possible use of what I am going to describe, but this book is about what comes before any of it.

It is not a book about being sensible with money. The money side of this book is simple and will take you very little time. The thinking takes longer, because it is mixed up with your career. That is why most books cover one or the other.

And it is not a book about being less ambitious. Optimize your Earning Power as hard as you can. Just do not let it be the only thing you optimize in your limited time on this planet.

The argument of this book is simple. Most of us started with very little money. We had time, energy and the ability to learn, so we sold our time and got better at selling it. That is why we are paid what we are paid today, and most people reading this have played that first half well. What I was never told is that there is a second half, in which some of that money is supposed to be turned back into time, steadily, so that the deal you made at twenty-two does not still run your life at fifty. First make your time valuable. Then make it yours.

I played the first half hard for about a decade, had a very good season, and found I had eight months and a closed mouth. The rest of this book is the detail, the math, and some decisions I got wrong, several of them with great confidence.

A note on how to read this book

There are several calculations in this book. None of them are hard or complex. The hardest thing you will do is divide one number by another. But the calculations only work if you do them on your own life, with real numbers. Reading about someone else's runway is interesting. Knowing your own will change what you say in meetings.

Each of the four calculations appears inside the chapter that explains it. Blank versions are at the back of the book. Four, no more.

One more thing. Both halves of what I am about to describe can be learned. Neither is a personality trait. I did not get better at either through a flash of insight sitting under a tree, though sitting under trees helped at times. I got better by finding out that each one breaks down into specific, boring, testable habits, and then practicing them for years. That is the most hopeful thing I know, and I will come back to it in chapter four.

PART ONE

The Formula

CHAPTER ONE

Better money, better life

A long time ago, many of us made a deal without realizing it. Before I show you the deal, I have to show you who helped write its terms, because we did not write them alone.

It was our parents and their generation. But let me first defend them before I complicate matters.

Those of us born in India in the late 1980s or the 1990s, mostly millennials, were raised by parents who had seen an economy with very little to hand out. Many of our families had little wealth to speak of, unless you count a steel almirah and firm opinions about which relatives could not be trusted. Jobs were few. Good jobs were fewer.

Private businesses were boxed in by the license raj, where getting permission to make more scooters took longer than making them. So, the kind of business culture that might have created jobs mostly did not exist. And the country was too poor to employ its own people well because a poor country cannot buy much from itself. In 1988, the year I was born, India's income per person stood at about $360 a year.[1] At the exchange rate of the time, that was roughly ₹5,000. Adjusted for inflation, it is about ₹62,000 to ₹67,000 in today's money. For a whole year.

You have already seen my own home. A government salary, a government roof, a mother who went to work when I

was five, and money as a permanent subject. Multiply that home by a few crore and you have the country your parents were living in.

So, when they pushed many of us toward engineering or medical, they were in fact reading the board correctly. At the time it felt like a failure of imagination, especially to the fifteen-year-old who wanted to do something else. I no longer think it was.

For a country in that position, the way out was to sell to the West, where the incomes and the spending were. There were two ways to do it. Make things the West would buy, which needed money the country did not have. Or provide services the West would pay for, which needed only skills and English. The colonial accident had left us the English, complete with phrases like "do the needful" that the English themselves had long since dropped. The skills, it turned out, could be trained. A growing technical workforce and firms able to organize that work helped turn the opportunity into an industry.[2]

A handful of people saw the whole shape of it early. Some had gone West in the 1970s and 1980s, into a technology industry that was growing faster than it could find people. Some built companies at home. They knew what Western companies paid for software work. They also knew what capable people in India would happily accept. The difference between those two numbers was one of the great business opportunities of the century, and India was sitting on top of it. Economists call this kind of price gap an arbitrage. Train people at home, deliver the work over the internet, keep a slice of the difference. That gap helped Infosys and its peers grow, alongside their ability to deliver work reliably and earn customers' trust. It worked spectacularly, for the companies and for the country, and it still does.

That is where many of the new jobs came from, and it is what our parents saw arriving. Families that had grown up

with few choices watched software companies offer young graduates a different path. A private salary, faster increases, an onsite posting, perhaps a life abroad. Government jobs still offered security and benefits that a salary comparison would miss, and government pay did rise through successive pay commissions.[3] But the new career's attraction was easy to understand. It became a matter of family pride. For some of us, going abroad became the plan before we had asked what life there would actually be like. That expectation still lives and thrives in many Indian homes.

So much of our middle-class ambition was pushed through one of two funnels: engineering or medical. Then came the exam machine that decided who got in. Marks became the family project, discussed with the seriousness other families save for cricket or food. Somewhere in the neighborhood there was always a child who had scored two marks more than you, and that name was used against you for years. *"Sharmaji ke bete ke dekho, uske zyada marks aaye hai"* became part of the national vocabulary. (No offense to Sharmaji or his son.)

Whatever many of us were good at, unless it was math or science, became a hobby to put away. The guitar went under the bed. The sketchbook went into a trunk. I am not going to argue about whether that was right. The new ambition had a cost, and I will come to the cost. But it was a sensible response to the board at the time as our parents saw it. They looked at their own lives, looked at the opportunity, and pointed us toward the side of it that paid. I think it came from love. After all, no parent wants their child to go through the hardship they went through.

And it worked. I want to say that clearly, because it has become fashionable to look down on it. A generation moved from one problem away from trouble to comfortable in about twenty years. Better homes, real healthcare, and foreign holidays with aesthetic photographs to prove it. An entire class of

people caught up to a semblance of the good life. The formula our parents handed us, better money means better life, paid out as promised for a long time.

The sentence I want you to hold

Keep the next sentence in mind. We will come back to it in chapter nine.

Much of our early advantage rested on being a capable option at a lower cost.

I mean that as a description of the trade, not an insult. Western companies could get good work done in India for a fraction of the cost. Around 2000, an engineer in the US cost roughly eleven to thirteen times as much as one in India.[4] At the same time, several Indian firms got very good at running large projects, hitting deadlines and winning repeat business, and that kept the customers coming back after the first contract.

Western companies soon found that the same model worked beyond IT for other business functions, such as human resources, finance, marketing, and administration, and moved much of that work to India as well. A whole new range of service jobs opened up. Many of them also realized they could improve the arbitrage further, and keep the talent, by building offshore units of their own that worked only for the global business. This is how India's global capability centers, also known as delivery centers, were born. Similar arbitrages were applied in other countries too, but India became a major drawer of this arbitrage.

Today, more than 2,100 multinationals run their own global capability centers (GCCs) in India, about 3,700 offices in all. Bangalore alone has more than 1,000 of them and a third of the people who work in them. Most of the rest are in Hyderabad, Pune, the Delhi NCR, Chennai and Mumbai. They have now matured enough to pull top jobs to India. In 2024, more than 6,500 global leadership roles were held from India, up from 115

in 2015.[5] So, within one generation, our parents watched their children go from getting much better paid jobs at multinationals to running important parts of them.

I feel proud of how far our generation has come and remain extremely hopeful for the generations after us. However, the fact remains. Much of the pyramid our generation climbed, including the campus placements, the onsite postings, the bands and the hikes, the first trip abroad where you photographed the airport, and now the new leadership positions, grew from that combination of capability and arbitrage of lower labor cost.

The cracks

Three cracks have since appeared in the formula. They arrived in order.

The first crack was hours. When crores of young people chase one funnel, the funnel gets choked and prices itself accordingly. Once everyone in the room is capable, capability stops setting you apart, and the market starts bidding on something else entirely, which is how many hours you will work in a day.

You have seen this at work. An eight-hour day became a twelve-hour day and began to look like commitment. Soon, the extra hours were expected. Work started to spread into the evenings, then Saturdays, then some Sundays, and you can't remember the meeting where this was agreed.

The second crack was control. The formula said better money means better life, and it assumed you would have time to live the better life. Nobody stopped to check that assumption, because everything was happening fast and everyone was busy chasing the next thing. Keeping up with the Joneses went on steroids in India, because no generation here had ever

seen incomes rise this fast. (Chapter fifteen is about what that does to a household.)

The generation that won this game got the high-paying jobs, the accompanying flats and the cars and found, somewhere in their forties, that the money could not buy back the time it had cost.

The third crack is one our parents could not have seen, because it has only just arrived, and it is still arriving.

The arbitrage trade was temporary, always. Being the cheapest capable option is a temporary market advantage, and they end when a cheaper capable option appears. For many of us, the advantage lasted long enough to feel like it would never change, and we chose to build our lives on ground we assumed was permanent.

You already know what the new cheaper option is. You may have used it this morning to draft an email to your boss. I am not going to discuss it yet, for two reasons. Discussing it properly needs tools you will only have by Part Two of this book. And about half of what is written on the subject is panic and the other half is denial, so let me refrain from adding a third half. For now, I will say only this. The arbitrage that explains where our jobs came from also explains what is happening to them. It is the same trade. This time, you are competing against technology rather than against people in another country.

We will return to that sentence in chapter nine. First, I want to look at what we can do about our own position: improve the work we are paid for and build enough financial room to choose where we do it. Most of us have spent far more time on the first than on the second. We learned early to make our time valuable. No one taught us how to make it ours.

NOTES AND SOURCES

1. India's GDP per person in 1988: World Bank, World Development Indicators, series NY.GDP.PCAP.CD, approximately US$358.48 in current dollars. This is economic output per person, not a salary or a purchasing-power comparison. https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/NY.GDP.PCAP.CD?locations=IN
2. The development of Indian IT: World Bank, "India's IT industry and industrial policy" (2012), on skills, export conditions, infrastructure and policy alongside costs. https://blogs.worldbank.org/en/developmenttalk/india-s-it-industry-and-industrial-policy
3. Late-1990s pay: a fresh software engineer's starting salary of around ₹2 lakh a year, against roughly ₹1 lakh to ₹1.4 lakh for a senior government officer under the Fifth Pay Commission scales. Both figures are approximate and vary by employer, grade and year. Government pay, allowances and pensions are not directly comparable with private salaries without a matched year and grade.
4. US and Indian engineering pay: around 2000, an engineer in the US cost roughly eleven to thirteen times as much as one in India. For experienced engineers the gap has since narrowed to roughly five to eight times. The median US software developer earned about $133,000 in 2024 (US Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics, May 2024), while an Indian engineer with similar experience earns roughly ₹15 lakh to ₹25 lakh (kaam.work, India Tech Salary Report 2026). Other sources: Reserve Bank of India, NACE, The Quint. Pay comparisons across countries depend on matching roles, experience and exchange rates, so treat these multiples as rough.
5. GCCs in India: Zinnov and nasscom, India GCC Landscape Report 2026 (data as of March 2026, released May 2026): 2,117 GCCs running 3,728 units and employing about 2.36 million people. https://zinnov.com/centers-of-excellence/zinnov-nasscom-india-gcc-landscape-2026-report/. City split: Zinnov, "How 6 Cities Made India the Global Capability Center Capital" (June 2026): Bengaluru 1,080+ units (about 29 percent of all units) and 34 percent of GCC talent; Hyderabad 515+, NCR 490+, Pune 475+, Chennai 405+, Mumbai 375+ units. https://zinnov.com/centers-of-excellence/how-6-indian-cities-made-india-the-gcc-capital-blog/. Global leadership roles: Zinnov, "5 Shifts Defining India's Global Capability Centers Story in 2025" (8 January 2026), citing Zinnov's 5-Year GCC Landscape Report: 6,500+ roles in 2024, projected to pass 30,000 by 2030. The 2015 figure of 115 is from Zinnov, "The Rise of Global Roles in India's GCCs" (July 2024).